

GUINEA PIG · CAVIA PORCELLUS

Keep your guinea pigs the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the floor space this species needs, the vitamin C rule that makes it different from every other small pet, heat as an emergency, the law in every state, and the health pages that help a guinea pig live out its full four to eight years.

INSIDE

- ✓ Floor space in square feet for one guinea pig or a pair, and temperature targets in Fahrenheit and Celsius
- ✓ Pairing, introductions and sexing, step by step
- ✓ Vitamin C by body weight, food charts and the never-feed list
- ✓ Eleven health pages, the antibiotic list to hand your vet, and fillable logs

51 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Lengths appear in inches (in), with centimeters (cm) beside them. Floor space is in square feet (sq ft), which is length times width: 30 by 36 inches is 7.5 sq ft. A guinea pig and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows, with pounds (lb) beside them. Vitamin C is counted in milligrams (mg) per kilogram (kg) of body weight, written mg/kg. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't brought any home yet

Check the law first, on page 23: a guinea pig is legal in every state, with one footnote. Then read pages 4 to 22 in order before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the enclosure, sized by floor area, and the number of guinea pigs, since this species needs company. Use the Budget & Shopping List on page 37 and buy once.

If your guinea pigs are already home

Start with vitamin C on page 11. It is the one requirement almost no other common small pet shares, and it is almost entirely preventable. Then audit the setup against the Setup Checklist, and if anything looks off, go to page 24: the safe waiting window for a guinea pig that has stopped eating is measured in hours.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 35: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 41: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine |
| ☐ Page 36: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 43: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 32: Antibiotics & Enterotoxemia | ☐ Page 44: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 40: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 45: Equipment & Vet Log |

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian (vet) who sees guinea pigs, often called a cavy-savvy exotic vet. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent is a vet call, not a page in this book, and the window for urgency is short. Find a vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. The law page is not legal advice either. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary sources on page 49.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Cavia porcellus</i> , the guinea pig, also called a cavy
Origin	Domesticated more than 3,000 years ago in the Andes. There is no wild population of this species
Adult size	8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm) and 1.5 to 2.6 lb. Boars (males) 900 to 1,200 g (2 to 2.6 lb); sows (females) 700 to 900 g (1.5 to 2 lb)
Lifespan	4 to 8 years
Diet type	Strict herbivore: unlimited grass hay, about 80% of the diet (page 10)
Vitamin C	Cannot make its own. 10 to 25 mg/kg a day for a healthy adult, 30 mg/kg or more if growing, pregnant, nursing or ill (page 11)
Floor space	7.5 sq ft for one guinea pig, 10.5 sq ft for a pair, with roughly 2 to 4 more sq ft for each additional animal (page 6)
Room	65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C) at 30 to 60% humidity. Heat stress can begin at 75°F (24°C) (page 7)
Company	Pairs or small groups. A guinea pig kept alone tends to become withdrawn or depressed (page 18)
Voice	Several distinct vocalizations, from the wheek to the purr (page 17)
Handling difficulty	Beginner, but a prey animal that must be supported at both ends and handled low to the ground
Vaccines required	None for this species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$300 to \$470 for the setup, every item priced, from a cage sized for a pair to the first bag of food, plus \$10 to \$60 for each guinea pig from a shelter or about \$50 at a pet store. An annual wellness exam runs \$50 to \$100. Every line is on page 37.

Monthly ongoing

\$75 to \$185 a month for a pair, which is the recommended minimum: \$60 to \$135 of hay, pellets and fresh vegetables, plus bedding and the vitamin C supplement. Food for one runs \$30 to \$70.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A sick or emergency visit runs \$100 to \$300 or more, and complex problems such as gastrointestinal stasis can push well past that. Neuter and spay fees are set clinic by clinic. None of this is likely if you follow this package, but plan for it.

Fun facts worth knowing

- The wheek, the loud squeal many owners know as the sound a fridge door brings on, is a learned response to expected food, not a fixed instinct.
- Guinea pigs, humans and fruit bats are among the mammals that lost the ability to make their own vitamin C, and in each case the same gene is the one that stopped working.
- Bell pepper carries more vitamin C by weight than an orange, which is why it tops the vegetable list for this species.

The species, coat types, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species

The pet guinea pig is *Cavia porcellus*, a rodent that has never been found in the wild. It is a fully domesticated species descended from South American wild cavies and bred by Andean peoples for more than 3,000 years, first as livestock and for religious ceremonies and now as one of the world's most popular small pets. It is valued for being vocal, social and gentle. Guinea pigs reached Europe soon after the first European contact with South America, arriving as luxuries kept by the upper classes. The oldest known European remains date to the sixteenth century.

Its Andean ancestry explains most of its habits: it lives in groups, it grazes most of the day (a wild guinea pig can spend up to 80% of it foraging), and it reads a lifted hand as a predator.

Coat types

The most common types are the English or American shorthair, the Peruvian (long-haired) and the Abyssinian (swirled hair). Teddy and Silkie are two other types. Care is the same across them, with two differences: the long-haired types (Peruvian, Silkie and Texel) need brushing every day, and specialty types cost more, from \$100 up, against \$10 to \$60 from a shelter or about \$50 at a pet store for a standard animal.

Size and growth

Adult length	8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm).
Adult weight	Boars 900 to 1,200 g (2 to 2.6 lb); sows 700 to 900 g (1.5 to 2 lb). Each animal has its own steady weight, and that figure is the one to track (page 14).
Growth	Babies start nibbling hay, pellets and vegetables within hours of birth while still nursing, and are fully weaned by 2 to 4 weeks. A guinea pig is growing, and eats differently, until about 6 months old (page 10).
Males and females	Boars are larger. Telling the sexes apart is easy to get wrong in young animals (page 22).

Lifespan

4 to 8 years is typical. That is a multi-year commitment, closer in scale to a rabbit or a cat than to a hamster, which lives 2 to 3 years. Plan for the whole span: the diet, the company and a vet who sees guinea pigs for every one of those years, and a second animal for as long as the first lives.

ONE ANIMAL IS NOT THE PLAN

The most commonly skipped part of guinea pig care is the companion, and it quietly doubles most of the numbers in the budget. Guinea pigs are herd animals. Budget for two from day one rather than adding a second later and being surprised by the jump.

Enclosure size, type & where it goes

Measured in square feet of floor, because guinea pigs run along the ground and do not climb or jump well.

GROUP	MINIMUM FLOOR AREA	NOTES
One guinea pig	7.5 sq ft	Roughly 30 by 36 in (76 by 91 cm). Possible, but not the recommended way to keep the species.
A pair	10.5 sq ft	The number to buy against, since a pair is the recommended minimum.
A larger group	Add roughly 2 to 4 sq ft	For each additional guinea pig beyond the first.

Bigger is always better here. Guinea pigs are active and use the room they are given, so the minimum is where to start, not a target to stop at. Why a pair is the starting point is on page 18.

The floor and the sides

- **Solid floor, never wire.** Wire flooring is a common cause of bumblefoot, a painful infection of the soles of the feet.
- **Sides at least 12 in (30 cm) high.** Height is not floor space, and a species that does not climb or jump well gets nothing from it.
- **Good ventilation.** Glass tanks and plastic bins both ventilate poorly, so they are out.

What to buy

A C&C enclosure, short for cubes and corrugated plastic, is built from wire storage cubes joined into a pen on a corrugated plastic base. It gives real floor area for the price and can be extended as a group grows. A ready-made single-level habitat of about 8 sq ft, at around \$100 to \$109, covers a single guinea pig. A pair needs a larger modular or C&C habitat, which runs closer to \$140. The enclosure is the biggest line in the setup budget, and it is worth getting the size right the first time rather than upgrading later.

Where it goes

- Out of direct sun and away from drafts and cold windows. The temperature page covers why.
- Out of reach of household cats and dogs.
- Somewhere it can see the room and hear quiet household life. An enclosure tucked away in a spare room gives a guinea pig less to take in, as long as a hide lets it get away from the noise when the family gets loud.
- Never shared with a rabbit, even for company. A rabbit that looks healthy can carry bacteria that make a guinea pig ill.

BUY ONCE

The common mistake is a cage that is technically big enough for one animal and too small for two. Measure the floor, not the label, and plan for the pair.

Temperature, humidity & heat stress

This is a health page, not a comfort page: a guinea pig has no sweat glands and cannot cool itself.

READING	°F	°C
Comfortable room range	65 to 79	18 to 26
Heat stress can begin	as low as 75	24
Heat stress most often seen	above 82	above 28
Humidity	30 to 60%	

The room is the enclosure's whole climate system: there is no lamp, no heater and no dial. Put a digital thermometer and humidity gauge in the room, out of direct sun, and check it. A room that feels merely warm to you can already be dangerous, and the comfortable ceiling sits only a few degrees below the point where trouble starts. Keep the enclosure out of direct sun and away from drafts.

Signs of heat stress, in order

1. **Rapid or open-mouth breathing.** Faster, shallower breaths than normal, sometimes visible as panting.
2. **Heavy drooling,** sometimes leaving the fur around the mouth wet, with a racing heart.
3. **Weakness and reluctance to move,** with pale gums.
4. **Severe signs:** tremors, convulsions, collapse, coma and death if untreated.

Do not wait for all four. A guinea pig can deteriorate quickly once heat stress starts, so the first sign, not the fourth, is the point to act.

Do, at once

- Move it to the coolest room, with good airflow and out of direct sun.
- Offer cool, not ice-cold, water, and do not force it to drink.
- Cool it gradually with a cool damp towel or a light wipe of cool water on the ears and feet.
- Get to a vet immediately. A guinea pig that looks calmer can still relapse.

Do not

- Do not plunge it into cold or ice water: that can send a stressed small animal into shock.
- Do not assume it will recover on its own once it looks calmer.
- Do not leave it in a parked car, even briefly, or in a carrier in the sun.

Keeping the room cool

- Move the enclosure to the coolest room, with air conditioning or at least moving air.
- Freeze water bottles and wrap them in a towel, so a guinea pig can choose to lie against one. Direct ice is too cold.
- Keep unlimited fresh water in more than one container, and offer water-rich foods such as cucumber.

Cold and drafts

A guinea pig handles a cool room reasonably well as long as the drop is gradual. The cold risk is a draft or damp bedding, which lose heat far faster than still, dry air at the same reading and can leave a cold-stressed animal with a respiratory infection. Extra hay gives it something to burrow into.

Bedding, hides & cage layout

What goes on the floor, what goes on top of it, and where.

Bedding

OPTION	VERDICT	NOTES
Paper-based bedding	USE	Recycled paper products are free of loose fibers. The usual first choice.
Fleece liners	USE	A washable option that also avoids loose fibers.
Kiln-dried pine	ACCEPTABLE	The one wood product generally accepted. Drying removes most of the oils.
Cedar, raw pine, sawdust	NEVER	The oils and dust irritate the respiratory system over time.

Wood shavings and chips are best avoided. Whatever the bedding, it has to stay dry: damp bedding is a cold risk and a foot risk, and unsanitary bedding is linked to bumblefoot.

Hides are not decoration

Constant access to a secure hiding place is close to a baseline need. A guinea pig is a prey animal, and one with nowhere to retreat stays on alert even in a calm room. Secure hiding options are linked to lower stress indicators.

- PVC (polyvinyl chloride) pipe, hide huts and fleece tunnels all work, and a seagrass hideout or tunnel adds something to chew in the same footprint.
- In a cage with more than one guinea pig, provide multiple hides. A single hide in a shared space tends to become something one animal guards, and a lower-ranking animal needs somewhere to go.
- Put out more than one of anything worth having, such as a tunnel, for the same reason.

Layout

FLOOR

Solid, with a thick layer of dry bedding. Spot-clean soiled areas every day.

HAY

Unlimited, in a rack or a pile, and also scattered across the enclosure so a shy guinea pig can always eat somewhere.

HIDES

More than one, in different spots, so nobody is shut out of cover.

WATER AND FOOD

A bottle with a working nozzle, or a heavy bowl, and a dish for pellets. A foraging mat or puzzle takes the place of a vegetable bowl.

CHEWING IS A NEED

A guinea pig's teeth grow for life, so gnawing is physical as well as natural. Untreated wood chews, hay-based chew sticks and cardboard tunnels all hold up. Skip cotton rope and other fabric fibers, which guinea pigs chew and swallow and which can block the gut.

Cleaning, water & hygiene

Guinea pigs are messy, so cleaning is a daily habit, not a monthly event.

HOW OFTEN	WHAT
Every day	Spot-clean soiled bedding. Change the water and check that the bottle nozzle runs. Pull uneaten fresh vegetables after 30 minutes to a couple of hours, so they do not spoil.
Often	Change all of the bedding, before it stays wet.
Regularly	Clean and disinfect water bottles. Some guinea pigs push a slurry of pellets up into the sipper tube, which makes frequent cleaning more important for them.

Why it matters

- **Feet.** Dirty or damp bedding is one of the causes of bumblefoot, along with wire flooring.
- **Lungs.** A damp, drafty enclosure is a more realistic road to a respiratory infection than a cool room.
- **Gut.** Fresh vegetables left out go off, which is why uneaten ones come out after a couple of hours at most.

Water

Fresh water has to be available all day, in a sipper bottle or a heavy bowl. A bottle is the better default, because guinea pigs drink more from one, and more water helps the urinary tract. Whichever you use, change the water daily and check the nozzle often.

NEVER ADD VITAMIN C TO THE WATER

It breaks down fast once dissolved, often losing much of its potency within hours, and it changes the taste, which can make a guinea pig drink less. A guinea pig that drinks less is at greater risk of bladder stones. The right ways to supply vitamin C are on page 11.

Hygiene

- Wear gloves and wash your hands when treating a guinea pig for ringworm, because it can spread to people. Some mite infestations can spread to the household too.
- Keep food and water dishes clean, and clean and disinfect bottles regularly.

Diet by age & unlimited hay

A guinea pig's gut depends on near-constant food, so skipping a meal is a much bigger deal here than for most pets.

DAILY COMPONENT	AMOUNT
Grass hay (timothy, orchard or oat/meadow)	Unlimited, always available, roughly 80% of the diet
Guinea pig pellets with vitamin C	About 1/8 cup (about 2 tablespoons) per guinea pig
Fresh leafy greens and vegetables	Roughly 1 cup of leafy greens per guinea pig, within a daily range of 1 to 2 cups of fresh produce
Treats, fruit included	Under about 10% of the daily diet
Water	Fresh and available at all times

Hay is the diet, not the filler

Guinea pigs graze near-constantly, so continuous access matters more than counting meals. Hay is unlimited at every life stage and should never run out. It does two jobs nothing else does: its long fiber keeps digestion moving, and the constant chewing wears down teeth that never stop growing. Hay is also the main prevention for dental disease and for a slowed gut. Alfalfa is a different thing, a legume with more calcium and protein than a healthy adult needs, so it is fed only at the stages below.

By age

STAGE	WHAT CHANGES
Baby	Starts nibbling hay, pellets and vegetables within hours of birth, even while still nursing, and is fully weaned by 2 to 4 weeks.
Juvenile, under about 6 months	Does best with alfalfa hay added alongside or instead of grass hay: the extra protein and calcium support growth.
Healthy adult	Grass hay is the staple. Alfalfa's richer profile can contribute to obesity if fed regularly, and its calcium adds to the bladder stone risk.
Pregnant, nursing, senior or ill	Benefits from alfalfa, and needs 30 mg/kg or more of vitamin C, against 10 to 25 mg/kg for a healthy adult (page 11).

A day's feeding

- **All day:** fresh hay and water, topped up before they run low.
- **Morning:** a measured portion of pellets. Measuring daily makes a drop in appetite obvious at once.
- **Any time:** fresh vegetables as a small handful, with anything uneaten pulled after 30 minutes to a couple of hours.

CHANGE FOODS SLOWLY

Guinea pigs set their food preferences early and do not adapt well to sudden changes. A new hay type or pellet brand can be refused simply for being unfamiliar. Introduce anything new gradually, one item at a time and in a small amount, and treat a guinea pig that has genuinely stopped eating as a medical problem, not fussiness (page 25).

Vitamin C: the daily rule

The one requirement generic small-pet advice always misses.

Guinea pigs cannot make their own vitamin C or store it. Rabbits, hamsters and chinchillas can, which is why general small-pet advice so often misses this. Without a daily source, collagen production breaks down over days to weeks, and collagen is what holds joints, gums, blood vessels and healing wounds together. That failure is scurvy (page 27).

WHO	PER KILOGRAM A DAY	IN DAILY TERMS
Healthy adult	10 to 25 mg/kg	About 20 to 25 mg for a typical adult
Growing, pregnant, nursing or ill	30 mg/kg or more	About 30 to 40 mg for a growing or pregnant guinea pig

The requirement scales with weight, so a flat figure is the wrong shape for the answer: a 1.1 kg (2.4 lb) boar and a 700 g (1.5 lb) sow do not need the same dose. Hold the daily figures in your head at the vegetable drawer, and hand the per-kilogram figures to a vet.

Where it should come from

Fresh vegetables, led by bell pepper, every day. A quarter of a medium bell pepper covers most of a typical adult's daily need. Red, yellow and orange peppers carry substantially more than green ones, and pepper is high in vitamin C and low in sugar. Dark leafy greens are strong secondary sources to rotate in. For a sense of the range, one cup of each of these carries about this much vitamin C:

FOOD, PER CUP	VITAMIN C	FOOD, PER CUP	VITAMIN C
Turnip greens	260 mg	Collard greens	140 mg
Mustard greens	252 mg	Parsley	140 mg
Dandelion greens	200 mg	Spinach	60 mg
Kale	192 mg	Orange	50 mg

What does not work on its own

- **Pellets.** Most are fortified at the mill, but vitamin C degrades with heat, light and humidity, and a meaningful share is gone within weeks, even in an unopened bag. Use pellets within 90 days of the manufacture date and buy a fresh bag more often than feels necessary. A guinea pig fed a complete-looking diet can still get scurvy if the label is the only vitamin C source.
- **The water bottle.** Vitamin C degrades quickly in water and changes the taste, and a guinea pig that drinks less is worse off.

A supplement, as oral drops or tablets given by mouth, is a reliable way to close a gap, and a vet directs it when a guinea pig is ill. It backs up fresh food and does not replace it.

CAN YOU GIVE TOO MUCH?

There is a wide safety margin with normal fresh-food feeding, because the excess is water-soluble and mostly passed in the urine. The goal is steady daily intake from real food, not a big single dose. Consistently very high supplemental doses have been loosely linked to kidney stones in some cases.

Vegetables & pellets

Where the vitamin C comes from, and the small, measured portion that sits on top of the hay.

Vegetables and greens

Fresh vegetables go in daily as a small handful, rotated among varieties, and the leafy greens come to roughly a cup per guinea pig. Rotation matters because a species prone to fixed preferences stays willing to try things, and because several greens carry a lot of calcium.

FOOD	VERDICT	WHY
Bell pepper	STAPLE	The standout: high in vitamin C and low in sugar. Red, yellow and orange carry more than green.
Romaine lettuce, cilantro	SAFE	Safe greens, and decent secondary sources of vitamin C.
Ripe tomato, cucumber, carrot, celery	SAFE	Cucumber is mostly water, useful in hot weather. Ripe tomato only: unripe tomato is toxic.
Broccoli, cauliflower, dandelion greens	SAFE	Good sources of vitamin C to rotate in.
Kale, spinach, parsley	ROTATE	Good food, but they add to the calcium load that ends up in the urine, so do not feed one of them every day.
Iceberg lettuce	NEVER	Essentially no nutritional value.

- Offer the vegetables as one small handful, any time of day, and take out anything uneaten after 30 minutes to a couple of hours, so it does not spoil.
- Add a new vegetable on its own and in a small amount, so any change in appetite or droppings can be traced to it.
- Hide chopped vegetables in a foraging mat or puzzle, or under hay, instead of a bowl: it is enrichment as well as food.

Pellets

Pellets are a measured topping on the hay, about 1/8 cup (about 2 tablespoons) per guinea pig, typically in the morning.

- **Guinea pig pellets only.** Rabbit and other rodent pellets contain no added vitamin C, because those animals can make their own.
- **Plain and timothy-based.** Choose plain pellets, because ones with nuts, seeds or dried fruit are too high in fat. Look for stabilized vitamin C on the label.
- **Used within about 90 days of manufacture,** since the vitamin degrades with light, air and time.
- **Alfalfa-based pellets** belong with young, pregnant, nursing or ill animals, not healthy adults.

WHY THE ROTATION MATTERS FOR THE BLADDER

Calcium that the body does not use ends up in the urine, and high-calcium foods add to the risk of bladder stones. Rotating greens, leaving alfalfa for the stages that need it, and keeping the water flowing are the dietary half of prevention (page 29).

Fruit, treats & the never-feed list

The smallest part of the diet, and the part with the real dangers in it.

Fruit and treats

Fruit is an occasional treat, not a staple. Small amounts of orange, kiwi, apple or pear are fine. Fruit is high in sugar, and too much can upset the balance of the intestinal bacteria and cause diarrhea. All treats together, fruit included, stay under about 10% of the daily diet.

FOOD	VERDICT	WHY
Orange, kiwi, apple, pear (small bits)	TREAT	Sugar. A small piece now and then.
Nuts, seeds, peanut butter, corn	SKIP	Not toxic, but too high in starch or fat. Guinea pigs pick them over hay and pellets, leading to nutrient gaps and obesity.
Bread, pasta, oats, dry cereal	SKIP	Same problem: too high in starch.
Alfalfa hay, for a healthy adult	SKIP	Too much calcium and protein. See page 10.
Iceberg lettuce	SKIP	Essentially no nutritional value.
Meat, eggs, dairy	NEVER	A strict herbivore. None of it belongs in the cage.

Genuinely toxic

NEVER FEED

Avocado (linked to heart muscle damage) · **chocolate** · **onions, garlic, chives and leeks** (can destroy red blood cells, with signs sometimes taking 3 to 5 days to appear) · **rhubarb** (high in oxalic acid, linked to bladder stones) · **raw potato, unripe tomato**, and the leaves or plants of either · **mushrooms** · **fruit pits and seeds**

Two rules that prevent most trouble

- **Check before offering.** If a food is not on the vegetable page or this one, look it up before it goes in the cage.
- **Nothing goes in the water.** Vitamin C in particular breaks down fast and can put a guinea pig off drinking.

The treats that suit this species best are the ones that are also food: a piece of bell pepper, a leaf of cilantro, a handful of fresh hay hidden somewhere to be found.

Weight & body condition

A gram scale is the most useful tool a guinea pig owner can have.

Weight changes show up before most illnesses do. Weigh each guinea pig once a week, at the same time of day, and write the number down (page 44). The trend over several weeks says more than any single reading.

ADULT	NORMAL WEIGHT
Boar (male)	900 to 1,200 g (2 to 2.6 lb)
Sow (female)	700 to 900 g (1.5 to 2 lb)

Each animal has its own steady figure, and that figure, not the range, is the one that counts.

What the scale is telling you

READING	WHAT TO DO
Steady	Carry on.
A steady fall	A reason to call a vet. Dental disease is one common cause, and anything that makes a guinea pig eat less will show here first (page 26).
A steady climb	Usually too much food and too little exercise. Check the pellet and fruit portions and add supervised floor time. Make any change to the diet gradually.
A sudden gain or loss	Possibly a medical problem, a tumor or a pregnancy included. Have a vet rule those out before changing the diet.

Body shape

Guinea pigs are shaped like a rounded brick, so the scale is not the whole test. Look down at the animal from above: sides that bulge outward point to excess weight. A guinea pig that has changed how it walks or become lethargic is worth a closer look too.

A weekly look-over, done while it is on the scale

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Bright, clean eyes, with no crusting, cloudiness or discharge | ☐ A coat with no bald patches, scabs or lumps |
| ☐ A clean nose and ears | ☐ Equal weight on all four feet, and no sores on the soles |
| ☐ Clean, unstained teeth, with the top front teeth overlapping the bottom | ☐ A clean, dry back end and formed droppings |

FORAGING AND WEIGHT

When you make food harder to find, a good way to add enrichment, weigh each guinea pig daily while you raise the difficulty, and ease off if one starts losing weight.

Handling & taming

Being lifted off the ground looks, to a guinea pig's instincts, exactly like a predator attack.

Picking one up

1. **Approach from the front**, where it can see you, and talk to it and stroke its head before you lift.
2. **One hand under the chest**, just behind the front legs.
3. **The other hand scoops and supports the hindquarters** at the same time. Both ends, always.
4. **Bring it in against your chest** so it feels supported and secure rather than dangling.

STAY LOW

Sit on the floor or a bed whenever you handle a guinea pig. A fall from even a modest height can be fatal for an animal this size, and that risk alone is reason enough to keep handling close to the ground. Never lift one by the limbs, the scruff or loose fur. Never flip one onto its back: it can damage the spine and is highly stressful even when it does not.

How often, and for how long

Daily handling builds trust. Keep sessions short at first and let them grow as the guinea pig relaxes. Many eventually enjoy long lap time, but that comfort is earned gradually, not assumed from day one. A well set up enclosure gives a guinea pig the secure home base that makes the trust-building easier.

Signs it is stressed

- Freezing in place
- Trying to hide or burrow away from you
- High-pitched squeaking
- Struggling to get free

Signs it is content

- A relaxed, loose body posture
- Soft chirping or purring sounds

If you see stress signs, set the guinea pig back down gently instead of pushing through the session. Guinea pigs show clear stress signals well before they would ever nip or bite, and most need only minimal restraint for basic handling and a vet exam. Reading those signals and responding to them is the whole skill.

Children

Young children should never carry a guinea pig unsupervised. The combination of a squirming animal and unsteady hands is a common way falls happen. Supervise any handling by a young child closely.

Grooming, nails & coats

Three routine jobs, and one that only applies to older boars.

Nails

Guinea pig nails need a trim roughly every 6 to 8 weeks. Overgrown nails are uncomfortable to walk on and, past a certain length, curl back into the pad. They also feed bumblefoot.

- Cut only the tip, clear of the quick: the blood vessel through the center of the nail, visible as a pink line on light nails.
- On a dark nail, hold a flashlight behind it, and the quick shows before you cut.
- Keep styptic powder out and open before you start, not after a nick. If you nick the quick, pressing the powder on for a few seconds normally stops the bleeding.
- A guinea pig that fights every trim can be wrapped snugly in a towel with one foot worked free at a time. Do one or two nails per sitting, so it does not come to dread the whole process.

Coat and brushing

A guinea pig has no dramatic seasonal molt: shedding runs low and continuous, so a steady trickle of loose fur is normal. Coat length decides the workload.

COAT	BRUSHING
Short-haired	At least every few days.
Long-haired (Peruvian, Silkie, Texel)	Daily, all year. These coats grow continuously rather than staying at a fixed length.

Mats are not just cosmetic. Mats that drag on the ground pick up bedding, urine and droppings, which means odor and skin irritation, and mats around the hindquarters can stop a guinea pig cleaning its own grease gland. Work a metal comb through in short sections. If matting has set in badly, trimming the fur short enough that it no longer drags is a reasonable fallback.

The grease gland

Guinea pigs have an active grease gland at the base of the spine, just above the anus, especially prominent in males. It can get greasy, matted and smelly. A mildly greasy patch means the gland is doing what it normally does, not that the animal is sick. Once buildup sets in, a butt bath or a gentle clean with a cotton swab and a mild cleaning agent is better than leaving it. It does not need daily attention: checking it when you trim nails is enough.

Baths

A guinea pig rarely needs one, and it is easy to over-stress the animal. Spot-clean a dirty patch with a damp cloth and dry it thoroughly. The one routine exception is the shallow butt bath for a greasy gland: shallow water, and the guinea pig dried thoroughly afterward.

OLDER BOARS

Males, older intact ones especially, have a pouch behind the anus where droppings can pack in. Check older boars for it, and ask a vet to show you how to clean it the first time.

Sounds & body language

A prey animal that hides illness well and talks more than most small pets.

Guinea pigs are most active around dawn and dusk, though many adjust to their owner's day. They communicate with wheeking, chutting, bubbling, rumbling, chattering, whining, chirping and shrieking, which makes them unusually expressive for a small rodent.

SOUND	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
Wheek	A loud, rising squeal. Hunger or excitement. It is a learned response to expected food, which is why the fridge door brings one on.
Purring, soft gurgling	Contentment.
Chutting	A gentle, rhythmic call that goes with calm exploring and curiosity.
Rumbling	A deep vibrating sound, often with a swaying walk. Normal during an introduction.
Teeth chattering or clacking	A warning. Keep your distance and do not push.
Squealing, whining or a sharp shriek	Fear or pain. Check on the animal.

NOT COMMUNICATION

Labored breathing, wheezing, clicking and coughing are signs of illness. They call for a vet, not a list of sounds to enjoy (page 28).

Body language

- **Popcorning**, repeated bouncing hops and twists, is a sign of excitement and a comfortable guinea pig.
- **Freezing** in place is what a frightened or stressed guinea pig does. It can make illness harder to spot, because a prey animal hides signs of pain.
- **Hiding or burrowing away** from a hand means it is stressed. A guinea pig that stays hidden all the time, shows little interest in food or its surroundings, or chews the bars repeatedly is telling you something about the setup or its health.

Normal behavior that looks odd

- **Eating its own droppings.** Guinea pigs eat some of their droppings directly from the body, and that is normal.
- **Neophobia.** Fear of anything new is common, so a new food or toy can be refused or ignored at first.
- **Constant foraging.** A wild guinea pig can spend up to 80% of the day foraging and feeding, most actively in the morning and evening.

A CHANGE IN A HABIT IS A SYMPTOM

Because guinea pigs mask illness, a change in routine behavior, such as eating less, hiding more or losing interest in their surroundings, deserves attention promptly, not a week of watching.

Pairs, groups & who lives together

The decision that shapes everything else, and the one where the honest answer is not a preference.

Guinea pigs are herd animals. A guinea pig kept alone tends to become withdrawn or depressed, which is why pairs or small groups are the standard from the start. It is the one rule that sets the species apart among common beginner pets, and it doubles the budget: food and vet visits for two, not one.

Which pairings work

PAIRING	WHAT TO EXPECT
Two sows	Works well, and needs no surgery.
Brothers raised together	Works well, and needs no surgery.
A neutered boar with one or more sows	Works well. The boar must be neutered, meaning he has had surgery so he can no longer father litters, before he lives with a sow, because pregnancy and birth carry real risks for a sow.
Unrelated adult boars	Can be paired, but it can take several attempts to find a match.
An intact boar with a sow	Do not. The risks to the sow are on page 22.
A rabbit	Never. A rabbit can carry bacteria that make a guinea pig ill without showing any signs itself.

Personality decides a pairing more than sex does. Neutering does not change a boar's behavior or stop fighting, so it buys nothing in a same-sex pair: its only job is to make a boar safe to house with sows.

Two of everything that matters

- **Hides.** More than one, so a lower-ranking guinea pig always has somewhere to go.
- **Tunnels and other items worth having.** More than one, for the same reason.
- **Water, bowls and hay.** Enough bottles, bowls and piles of hay that nobody has to compete for them.
- **Floor space.** 10.5 sq ft is the minimum for a pair, so more is better.

When a companion matters most

A prey animal separated from its bonded companion in an unfamiliar place carries two stresses instead of one. A hospitalized guinea pig can benefit greatly from a bonded cage mate staying alongside it, and the reason is appetite: guinea pigs tend to stop eating when stressed, and one recovering alone in a strange cage has one more reason to skip a meal. Ask the clinic whether it can house a cage mate, and take the companion along when the visit allows it.

WHERE TO GET A PAIR

Shelters and rescue groups often have bonded pairs and are the first place to look. Whatever the source, check the sex of each animal yourself before two of them share a cage.

Introducing & bonding two guinea pigs

Most of what an introduction looks like is normal. The setup decides how it goes.

A new guinea pig is quarantined behind a closed door for 2 to 3 weeks before it meets anyone, so it cannot pass mites or illness to the others. Then the introduction happens on neutral ground, never in the resident's cage, where a newcomer is treated as an invader.

1. **Pick a room neither guinea pig lives in**, bigger than the cage and with no furniture to hide behind. A bathroom or hallway works.
2. **Set it up bare**. Towels on the floor, water bottles, and two large piles of hay, but no houses and no pellet bowls, both of which start fights.
3. **Put them in and sit still**. Keep your hands off and stay quiet for at least an hour, counted from when they settle, not from when they go in.
4. **Prepare the cage meanwhile**. Clean it out completely so it smells of no one, and give every guinea pig its own hide with two exits, plus enough bottles, bowls and hay for all.
5. **Move them in together** once they are calm and tired, and watch for another hour or two.

NORMAL, LEAVE IT ALONE

Mounting · loud chattering · chasing · pulling tufts of hair · rumble-strutting with the fur puffed up · raising noses at each other · wide yawns that show the teeth

SEPARATE THEM

Two guinea pigs rearing up on their hind legs at the same time · a locked, rolling fight · any deliberately drawn blood, which ends the introduction for the day

Never break up a fight with bare hands

A fighting guinea pig bites hard enough to reach bone. Drop a towel over both animals and separate them with the towel. Keep a towel within reach during every introduction.

What to expect

Chasing and rumbling carry on through the first week. By about two weeks, the new order has usually settled. If it does not settle, personality is usually the reason, since it decides a pairing more than sex does.

ORDER MATTERS

Quarantine first, sexing confirmed before they ever share a space, neutral ground, then the clean cage. Quarantine exists so a newcomer cannot carry mites or illness into the group.

Enrichment & common mistakes

Cover and work-for-it food lower stress and keep a prey animal active.

Foraging comes first

A guinea pig fed from one bowl loses most of its natural day. Scatter hay across the enclosure instead of piling it in a corner, and hide small amounts of chopped vegetables in a foraging mat, a wooden foraging puzzle or a tunnel rather than a dish. Make it harder as they learn: wrap a vegetable in a paper parcel or a small cardboard box that has to be chewed open, cover a dish with paper, or set out several dishes with food in only some. Start a box open until they know food lives inside, then close it bit by bit. In a 2025 survey of 1,181 guinea pig keepers, Elsbacher and colleagues found that those who offered food enrichment more often reported more play and friendlier behavior.

Chew, new things and views

- **Chew items.** Untreated wood chews, hay-based chew sticks and cardboard tunnels hold up. Rotate a few options, since guinea pigs vary in what they will engage with.
- **New things, slowly.** Many guinea pigs are neophobic, so add one item at a time. Choose sturdy pieces too large to swallow, and skip cotton rope and other fabric fibers.
- **Sound and view** count too: a guinea pig that can see the room and hear quiet household life has more to take in, as long as a hide lets it get away when the family gets loud.

Supervised floor time

A large enclosure cannot fully replace open floor. Time in a guinea-pig-proofed room or playpen lets them run, popcorn and investigate new smells and textures. Keep the space free of cords, gaps they could squeeze into, and anything toxic, and supervise directly: never leave them unattended outside the enclosure.

Ten mistakes, and the fix

THE MISTAKE	WHAT TO DO INSTEAD
One guinea pig, kept alone	Two, from the start
Wire flooring	A solid floor, always
A glass tank or plastic bin	An enclosure with good ventilation, such as a C&C pen
Cedar, raw pine or sawdust bedding	Paper, kiln-dried pine or fleece
Relying on pellets for vitamin C	Fresh vegetables daily, led by bell pepper
Vitamin C added to the water	Never: it breaks down and puts them off drinking
Alfalfa hay or iceberg lettuce for an adult	Grass hay, and nutritious greens
A hot room or direct sun	Under 79°F (26°C), out of the sun
A single hide in a shared cage	Multiple hides, and more than one of anything worth having
Waiting to see whether it starts eating again	A vet call at 8 to 12 hours without food or droppings

Choosing a healthy guinea pig & quarantine

Look at the animal, then at where it lives.

Where to get them

Shelters and rescue groups are the first place to look, and they often have pairs. Whoever the seller is, look at where the animals live first: it should be clean, have little odor, and not be overcrowded. Ask where the guinea pigs came from, whether a vet has checked them and what they are used to eating, and ask whether the seller will take one back if a vet finds it sick or pregnant. A young female kept in with males may already be pregnant, since sows can conceive from 2 months old or younger.

What to look at before you take one home

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Well fed and alert | ☐ A clean, dry back end |
| ☐ Bright, clean eyes with no crusting or cloudiness | ☐ A coat with no bald patches |
| ☐ A clean nose and ears | ☐ Clean, unstained teeth, the top front teeth overlapping the bottom |
| ☐ Formed droppings, with no diarrhea | ☐ Equal weight on all four feet, with no sores on the soles |

A nervous guinea pig is normal. It should calm down and respond to gentle stroking.

Quarantine is not optional

A new guinea pig that joins a household with others goes into quarantine behind a closed door for 2 to 3 weeks before it meets anyone, so it cannot carry mites or illness into the group. It guards against mites, ringworm and other illness. Ringworm also spreads to people.

The first vet visit

Find a vet who sees guinea pigs before you need one, and book a wellness exam early. A general small-animal clinic is not always equipped for guinea pig problems, so ask how many guinea pig procedures the clinic handles in a typical month. An annual wellness exam runs \$50 to \$100, and no vaccines are required for this species. Take the cage mate along when the visit allows it.

BRING TO THE VISIT

A hard-sided, ventilated carrier with a hide spot and a layer of hay, your weight log, a note of appetite and droppings, and the questions on the vet-visit page (page 33).

Sexing, neutering & the breeding deadline

Mistaking the sexes is common, and the consequences arrive fast.

How to sex a guinea pig

Hold the guinea pig upright against your chest with its hindquarters supported, and press gently just above the genital opening.

SEX	WHAT YOU SEE
Boar	The penis can be eased out, and the testicles show as two scrotal sacs. The area looks like a dotted letter <i>i</i> .
Sow	Nothing comes out. The opening is a Y-shaped slit.

A newborn female can look swollen, and a young male's testicles are small, so inexperienced sellers and owners often get young animals wrong. If you are not sure, have a vet check at the first visit.

The timings that make this urgent

EVENT	WHEN
A sow can conceive	From 4 to 5 weeks old
A boar becomes fertile	At about 8 to 10 weeks
A sow can conceive again	Within hours of giving birth, so the boar is removed before the birth or straight after it
Pups weaned	At 14 to 28 days
Gestation	59 to 72 days; a litter is usually 2 to 4 pups, born furred and soon eating solid food

Why a first litter late in life is dangerous

A sow's pelvic bones separate to let the pups out. If she has not had young by roughly 6 to 9 months, those bones fuse, and a first litter after that can end in obstructed labor. That, along with the risks of pregnancy itself, is why a boar is neutered before he lives with a sow.

Neutering

A male must be neutered before he lives with a female. It does not change a boar's behavior or stop fighting, so it buys nothing in a same-sex pair. A neutered boar can still father young for some weeks after surgery, so he stays apart from sows until the vet says it is safe. Fees are set clinic by clinic, and a quote should include the anesthesia and pain relief: get one from a vet who sees guinea pigs before settling on a mixed pair. Spaying a female is the more complicated operation (page 30).

Is a guinea pig legal where you live?

The least restricted animal on the exotic pet law map.

This page covers all 50 states, the District of Columbia and New York City, which has its own rules: 52 jurisdictions. A pet guinea pig is **legal with no permit in 51** and **legally allowed on a condition in 1**, Hawaii. No state bans it, none requires a permit to keep one, and only Hawaii requires a permit to bring one in.

WHERE	STATUS	THE RULE
Hawaii	Conditional	Listed by binomial, <i>Cavia porcellus</i> (carried with the older name <i>Cavia cobaya</i>), on the List of Conditionally Approved Animals (Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-6.5). Bringing one in needs an import permit from the Department of Agriculture and Biosecurity before it ships and a certificate of veterinary inspection signed within seven days of arrival, and it enters through Honolulu airport only.
California	Legal	Title 14 § 671 restricts the whole order of rodents, then names exceptions, domesticated guinea pigs among them. Cities and counties may still prohibit what the state allows.
Connecticut	Legal	The whole rodent order sits in Category Two, which bars private possession, and nine species are excepted. The guinea pig is one (§ 26-55-6).
Georgia	Legal	Rodents need a license except the genus <i>Cavia</i> , named in Rule 391-4-8-.05.
New Jersey	Legal	On the closed exempt list at New Jersey Administrative Code 7:25-4.4, the only route to keeping an animal there with no permit.
New York City	Legal	Named in Health Code § 161.01(c), which also bars the capybara and other large rodents.
District of Columbia	Legal	Inside the permitted category "domesticated rodents and rabbits" (District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j)(1)(C)).
Massachusetts	Legal	On the domestic animal list (Massachusetts regulations, title 321, section 9.02(3)). An unlisted vertebrate there is presumed wild.

Legal with no permit: 51 jurisdictions

Alabama, Alaska, Arizona, Arkansas, California, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, the District of Columbia, Florida, Georgia, Idaho, Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Kansas, Kentucky, Louisiana, Maine, Maryland, Massachusetts, Michigan, Minnesota, Mississippi, Missouri, Montana, Nebraska, Nevada, New Hampshire, New Jersey, New Mexico, New York State, New York City, North Carolina, North Dakota, Ohio, Oklahoma, Oregon, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, South Carolina, South Dakota, Tennessee, Texas, Utah, Vermont, Virginia, Washington, West Virginia, Wisconsin and Wyoming.

In twelve of them, California, Colorado, Illinois, Kentucky, Maryland, Michigan, Montana, Nevada, North Carolina, Ohio, Oregon and Washington, the state lets cities or counties be stricter, so check your local ordinance (a city or county law) too. In Nevada, Clark County, Las Vegas and Henderson are all stricter than the state.

What does bind a guinea pig owner

State law is effectively silent, so the limits that bite are lease terms, homeowners' association rules and the occasional municipal cap on the number of animals. No state or federal rule in the United States requires guinea pigs to be kept in pairs; Switzerland's Animal Protection Ordinance (Article 13, in force since 2008) does, and that rule circulates online without the country attached.

NOT LEGAL ADVICE

State legal status as of October 2026. This is a summary of state rules, read on 1 October 2026, and not legal advice. Rules change. Before you buy or move, check with your state wildlife agency and with your city or county.

Red flags, the 8 to 12 hour rule & finding a vet

For most pets, a skipped meal is nothing. For this one it is the alarm.

Guinea pigs hide illness well, and their digestion depends on food moving through continuously. The point to call a vet is **8 to 12 hours without eating or producing droppings**, and once the gut has stopped, it can become life-threatening within 24 to 48 hours.

SAME DAY, NO WAITING

Not eating, or eating noticeably less · no droppings, or droppings that are small, dry or few · labored, noisy or open-mouth breathing, wheezing or clicking · a hunched, tense posture or audible teeth grinding · a bloated or firm abdomen · drooling · diarrhea · straining or crying out to urinate, or blood in the urine · panting, drooling or weakness in warm weather · lethargy · a pregnant sow that stops eating, or one not delivered by day 70

WITHIN A FEW DAYS

Steady weight loss · hair loss, scabs or intense scratching · a new lump anywhere, particularly the neck · limping or stiffness · discharge from the eyes or nose, or repeated sneezing · red, swollen or sore soles · a wet chin · hair loss down both flanks of a sow

Finding a vet before you need one

- Look for a vet who sees guinea pigs, often called cavy-savvy. General small-animal clinics are not always equipped for guinea pig problems, and a vet who mostly sees dogs and cats can get fasting, drug choices and recovery priorities backwards without meaning to.
- Ask how many rabbit or guinea pig procedures the clinic handles in a typical month. An answer that is confident and specific tells you something before an emergency does.
- Book an annual wellness exam even when everything looks fine, because guinea pigs hide illness well.
- Write down a backup 24-hour emergency option too, somewhere you will find it at 11 at night. Questions to ask any clinic are on page 33.

Normal numbers worth knowing

MEASURE	NORMAL
Weight, adult boar	900 to 1,200 g (2 to 2.6 lb)
Weight, adult sow	700 to 900 g (1.5 to 2 lb)
Breathing	40 to 100 breaths a minute, quiet and through the nose

Have ready when you call

Its current and usual weight, when it last ate and what, when you last saw a normal dropping and what the droppings look like now, whether it is drinking, and any change in the last week such as a new food, new bedding, a new cage mate or a hot day.

Gastrointestinal stasis & a pig that stops eating

The emergency this species is most likely to have, and the one with the shortest fuse.

Gastrointestinal (GI) stasis means the gut, the stomach and intestines, slows or stops moving food through. It usually comes from inadequate fiber, dehydration, pain or stress. It is both a cause and an effect of not eating, which is what makes it a genuine emergency.

Signs, and the line

- Reduced or absent droppings, or droppings gone small or dry.
- Lethargy or reluctance to move, and a hunched, tense posture.
- Audible teeth grinding, which signals pain.
- A bloated or firm abdomen, and noticeable weight loss.
- Reduced water intake, and labored breathing.

THE CLOCK

Call a vet at 8 to 12 hours without eating or producing droppings. Once stasis sets in, it can become life-threatening within 24 to 48 hours. A low body temperature alongside these signs makes it more urgent still.

Why a guinea pig stops eating

CAUSE		NOTES
1	Dental disease	The most commonly cited cause. Overgrown back molars are painful and easy to miss.
2	GI stasis itself	Slowed motility from too little fiber, dehydration, pain or stress.
3	Illness or pain elsewhere	Respiratory infection, bladder stones, arthritis or injury commonly suppress appetite.
4	Environmental stress	A new home, a moved cage, new cage mates or loud noise.
5	Fear of new food	A new hay type or pellet brand turned down for being unfamiliar. Introduce changes gradually.
6	Pregnancy toxemia	A risk in overweight or late-term pregnant sows.
7	Vitamin C deficiency	Decreased appetite is one of the earliest signs, appearing within 2 to 3 weeks of a deficient diet.

What the vet does

Treatment is supportive: fluids for dehydration, assisted feeding with a critical care diet, pain relief and drugs that get the gut moving again, alongside a search for the underlying cause. A vet may send you home to give food and medicine by syringe, placed into the side of the mouth and past the loose tissue behind the front teeth. With prompt care many guinea pigs improve within 24 to 72 hours, though full recovery can take several days to a week.

Prevention is unlimited hay, fresh vegetables, constant water, supervised floor time, regular checkups, and a daily look at appetite and droppings (page 34).

Dental disease

Every tooth grows for life, and the ones that go wrong are the ones you cannot see.

All of a guinea pig's teeth, the front incisors and the cheek teeth, grow throughout life. The cheek teeth at the back are where trouble usually starts: the molars can overgrow even when the front teeth look completely normal, which is part of why the condition catches owners off guard. When an adult's incisors suddenly look overgrown, the problem is often at the back of the mouth.

Signs, which are vague and that is the problem

Eating	From mild pickiness to refusing food. Reluctance to eat despite interest in food. Difficulty chewing or swallowing.
Mouth and chin	Drooling, or a wet, matted chin and neck (the "slobbers").
Body	Weight loss and reduced activity.
Droppings	Unusually small, because less is going in.

Why it happens

Teeth stay the right length by wearing against each other, and the wear comes from chewing hay. A diet where hay is an afterthought lets the teeth drift out of alignment, and uneven wear makes the misalignment worse. Prevention is a proper hay-based diet with unlimited hay, plus chew items. Low-quality diets, vitamin C deficiency, infection, trauma and inherited jaw faults are other causes.

Treatment, and what to expect

- A vet has to examine the back teeth with special instruments, because the mouth is a small, narrow opening.
- Treatment is reducing the crowns, the visible tooth height, with a dental drill under general anesthesia, and sometimes pulling a severely diseased tooth.
- Severe or chronic cases can need the procedure repeated as often as every 4 to 6 weeks. Chronic cases mean repeat procedures, which is part of why prevention matters.
- Ask whether the clinic does this routinely and has the equipment, since a general small-animal clinic may not.

DO NOT TRY THIS AT HOME

Reducing the teeth is done by a vet with a dental drill under general anesthesia. The prevention at home is unlimited hay.

Scurvy: stages, treatment & recovery

One of the more common preventable illnesses in pet guinea pigs, and easy to miss early.

Scurvy is vitamin C deficiency. Vitamin C is essential for making collagen, the structural protein that holds together skin, blood vessels, joints and connective tissue, so without a reliable daily source collagen production breaks down over days to weeks. The effects show up wherever collagen matters most: joints, gums, blood vessel walls and wound healing. It also weakens the immune system and disrupts normal bone and tooth development.

Recognizing it by stage

STAGE	WHAT YOU WILL SEE
Early	A rough or puffed coat, mild lethargy, a slightly reduced appetite, subtle stiffness when moving. Appetite loss appears within 2 to 3 weeks of a deficient diet.
Progressing	Swollen, painful joints, reluctance to move or bear weight, weight loss and slow wound healing.
Advanced	Bleeding gums, spontaneous bruising, joint hemorrhage and diarrhea. A genuine emergency at this stage.

The early signs are easy to miss or blame on something else. A guinea pig that seems slower or less interested in food than usual is worth a closer look at the diet before assuming it is nothing.

Treatment

A guinea pig showing signs of scurvy needs a vet visit, not a wait-and-see approach, especially once joint pain or gum bleeding is visible. Treatment combines vet-directed vitamin C by mouth or by injection, depending on severity, with an immediate correction of the diet.

Recovery

- Early and moderate cases often improve within one to two weeks of proper treatment.
- Advanced cases, with real joint damage or significant weight loss, take longer and can leave some lingering stiffness. That is the strongest argument for catching it early.

Why it happens in households that think they are feeding well

Most pellets are fortified with vitamin C when milled, but vitamin C is unstable, and much of it is gone within weeks even in an unopened bag. Relying on the pellet bag's label as the only source is one of the most common ways owners end up with a scurvy case despite feeding a complete diet.

PREVENTION IS SIMPLE, JUST NOT OPTIONAL

Daily fresh vegetables, led by bell pepper, alongside a quality hay-based diet. With that, a guinea pig never has to rely on its pellets' vitamin C at all.

Respiratory infection & pneumonia

Urgent because of one anatomical fact.

Respiratory infections are caused by bacteria such as *Bordetella bronchiseptica*, *Streptococcus* and *Staphylococcus* species, and they are made more likely by poor husbandry, vitamin C deficiency and a young age. Pneumonia can end in sudden death.

OBLIGATE NASAL BREATHERS

Guinea pigs cannot breathe through the mouth as a fallback when the nose blocks. A guinea pig breathing with its mouth open needs a vet immediately.

Same-day signs

- Sneezing, nasal or eye discharge.
- Noisy or labored breathing, including wheezing and clicking.
- Lethargy and a drop in appetite.

All of these warrant a same-day vet visit rather than wait-and-see.

Where it comes from

SOURCE	WHAT TO DO
Drafts and damp bedding	Keep the enclosure out of drafts and away from cold windows, and keep bedding dry. Draft and damp are the realistic road to a cold-stressed, respiratory-compromised animal.
Cedar, raw pine and sawdust	Their oils and dust irritate the respiratory system over time. Use paper, fleece or kiln-dried pine.
Glass tanks and plastic bins	Poor ventilation. Use a well-ventilated enclosure.
A rabbit in the same cage	Rabbits can carry <i>Bordetella</i> without looking ill and pass it on. Never house the two together.
Vitamin C deficiency	Weakens the immune system. Fresh vegetables daily.

Treatment

Antibiotics are the treatment, and the choice matters, because several common ones are dangerous to guinea pigs. The antibiotic page (page 32) is the one to bring to the appointment. Treatment is not something to improvise at home.

A SNEEZE IS NOT ALWAYS AN INFECTION

One sneeze after a dusty bedding change is not a call. Repeated sneezing, discharge, noisy breathing or any change in appetite or activity is.

Bladder stones & urinary problems

Common, painful, and the one area where the vegetable list has consequences.

Roughly 90 percent of stones in guinea pigs are calcium carbonate, which sets them apart from the struvite or oxalate stones common in dogs and cats. That difference matters: there is no prescription diet or medication that dissolves a calcium carbonate stone once it has formed. Surgical removal, a cystotomy, is generally the only way to resolve one. Small stones sometimes cause few or no symptoms at first, so by the time a stone is caught it may already need surgery. Males face the higher risk of a life-threatening blockage of the urethra.

Signs: same-day vet

- Squeaking or crying out while urinating.
- Straining or repeated attempts to urinate, and a hunched posture.
- Blood in the urine, and urine staining or matted fur around the hindquarters.
- Not eating. A stone can also cause a partial or complete blockage, which is a true emergency.

What raises the risk

FACTOR	WHAT TO DO
Alfalfa hay or alfalfa pellets in an adult	The biggest dietary lever. Grass hay for healthy adults, since alfalfa is only for young, pregnant or nursing guinea pigs.
The same high-calcium greens every day	Kale, spinach and parsley add to the calcium load in the urine. Rotate them.
Low water intake	Concentrated urine makes crystals more likely. A bottle tends to increase daily intake over a bowl.
Rhubarb	High in oxalic acid and linked to bladder stones. Never feed it.

After a stone

Increasing water intake and reducing calcium are the cornerstones of managing a guinea pig prone to stones. Neither is a guarantee. Medical management on its own is often unrewarding and recurrence after surgery is common, so diet and water intake stay worth watching well after a stone has been removed.

If a secondary bladder infection is part of the picture, a vet may prescribe antibiotics. Guinea pigs tolerate only a narrow list of them safely, so ask which drug it is before the first dose (page 32).

A READING ON URINE

Urine runs from pale to reddish-brown depending on the diet, so color alone does not mean blood. Straining, crying out while urinating, and a stained rear end do mean a bladder problem.

Ovarian cysts, pregnancy & spaying

Very common in sows, and easy to mistake for a skin problem.

Ovarian cysts are extremely common in unsprayed female guinea pigs, and the risk climbs with age. They are found in more than half of female guinea pigs. The most visible sign is hair loss, which gets mistaken for a skin problem rather than a reproductive one.

SIGN	OVARIAN CYSTS	SKIN MITES
Hair loss pattern	Symmetrical, both flanks	Patchy, wherever scratching is worst
Itching	None	Intense, constant
Skin underneath	Looks normal	Red, irritated, scabbed or raw
Other signs	Crusty or enlarged nipples, abdominal swelling, lethargy	Flaky skin, possible secondary infection

An older intact female losing hair evenly on both sides without scratching points toward cysts before mites. Functional cysts secrete hormones and are the ones behind the hair loss, nipple changes and sometimes aggressive or mounting behavior. Non-functional cysts do not, but can still cause discomfort by growing large enough to press on nearby organs, with a firm or swollen abdomen, lethargy or a drop in appetite.

Diagnosis and treatment

A vet may feel an enlarged ovary by palpating the abdomen, but ultrasound is the more reliable way to confirm a cyst. Spaying, an ovariectomy, is the definitive treatment. It resolves the cysts and stops them recurring on remaining ovarian tissue. Surgery carries more risk in an older or already-debilitated guinea pig, so catching it early makes a real difference.

Should a healthy female be spayed?

That is the case for a preventive spay, and it is one exotics vets make for young, healthy sows. At that age the ovaries alone can be removed through a small incision in each flank, a shorter surgery than the traditional belly approach. It keeps the surgeon clear of the large cecum, the pouch of the gut where fiber ferments, and lowers the risk of pain, appetite loss and GI stasis afterward. An older female with cysts usually needs the full ovariectomy, because the uterus is often diseased too. The time to raise it is while she is young and healthy. A sow kept only with other females needs no spay for contraception, so for her the decision rests on cyst risk alone.

Pregnancy and pregnancy toxemia

Pregnancy lasts 59 to 72 days, and a sow that has not delivered by day 70 needs a vet immediately. Exhaustion, persistent unproductive contractions or heavy bleeding during labor are also reasons to go straight to one. Pregnancy toxemia is the other serious risk, most likely in overweight sows or those not eating well, which is why a pregnant guinea pig that stops eating is an emergency and not a 12-hour wait.

Mites, lice, ringworm, lumps, bumblefoot & boar butt

The outside of the animal, and two of these can transfer to you.

Hair loss and itching

All of these cause hair loss, crusting or flaky skin, and each needs a vet to tell it apart and treat it.

CAUSE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Mange mites	Intense itching, so severe that the scratching can look like a seizure. A guinea pig that suddenly thrashes or runs while scratching hard may have mites rather than a neurological problem. The skin underneath ends up crusty, raw and prone to infection.
Lice	Hair loss and crusty lesions, typically around the face, behind the ears or over the shoulders. A vet confirms them under a microscope.
Ringworm	A fungus, not a worm. Circular patches of hair loss ringed by inflamed, crusted skin, most often on the face, head and ears.

CATCHABLE BY PEOPLE

Ringworm and some mite infestations can spread to people in the household. Wear gloves and wash your hands when treating a guinea pig, and treat promptly rather than letting these run their course.

Bumblefoot (pododermatitis)

A painful foot infection linked to wire flooring or unsanitary bedding, and also to obesity, arthritis, overgrown nails and vitamin C deficiency. Mild cases are treated with topical care, bandages, pain relief and vitamin C while the cause is fixed. A deep infection leaves the animal lame and in pain. Check the soles during the weekly look-over: redness, swelling or a sore calls for a vet. Solid-floor housing with clean bedding goes a long way toward preventing it.

Lumps in the neck

Often an infected lymph node (cervical lymphadenitis) that follows a scrape inside the mouth. It shows as a large swelling on one side of the neck and is treated with surgery and antibiotics. Any new lump needs a vet, since abscesses, cysts and benign skin tumors all look alike from the outside.

Boar butt: an impacted rectal pouch

Males, older intact ones especially, have a pouch behind the anus where droppings can pack in. Left alone it causes smell, irritation and infection. Check older boars for it and ask the vet to show you how to clean it. Castration prevents it.

Antibiotics & enterotoxemia

Print this page. It is the one to hand over at a clinic you have not used before.

Guinea pigs ferment fiber in an enlarged cecum packed with bacteria, and those bacteria are overwhelmingly gram-positive, a broad group of bacteria. Certain antibiotics are built to target gram-positive bacteria. Given by mouth, they wipe out the gut flora, and a toxin-producing bacterium, *Clostridioides difficile*, overgrows and floods the body with toxin. The result is enterotoxemia, and it can be rapidly fatal. A dog-safe antibiotic can kill a guinea pig.

ASK BEFORE THE FIRST DOSE, BY ANY ROUTE

Penicillins: penicillin, ampicillin, amoxicillin, amoxicillin-clavulanate	Should not be given to guinea pigs
Lincosamides: clindamycin, lincomycin	Should not be given to guinea pigs
Macrolides: erythromycin, tylosin	Unsafe for guinea pigs
Cephalosporins	Same drug family as the penicillins, with the same risk
Bacitracin, including topical ointment if licked	Unsafe for rodents
Streptomycin	On the do-not-give list for rodents
Injectables containing procaine	Guinea pigs are sensitive to procaine penicillin

What a vet can usually use instead

Options generally usable in guinea pigs, because they have less effect on gram-positive bacteria, include trimethoprim-sulfamethoxazole, chloramphenicol and fluoroquinolones such as enrofloxacin. That is the shape of the conversation with your vet, not a prescription to self-select. The route matters too: oral dosing carries more risk than an injectable form of the same drug, because it passes directly through the gut where the flora lives.

What it looks like

Diarrhea, often watery and sometimes bloody or greenish-brown, loss of appetite, lethargy and a drop in body temperature. A guinea pig typically goes limp, dehydrated and cold, with death one to two days after the diarrhea begins. Any diarrhea, appetite loss or lethargy that starts during or shortly after an antibiotic course is a call-the-vet-now situation, not something to monitor overnight, and stopping the antibiotic is usually the first step the vet will want to take. Do not wait for the next scheduled dose.

Say this at the clinic

THE QUESTION

"Is this antibiotic one of the ones known to cause fatal diarrhea in this species, and have you prescribed it to a guinea pig before?" A vet experienced with exotics will have an immediate answer. One who does not may need to look it up, and that is a reasonable thing to ask before the prescription is filled. Ask which drug it is, and whether it works against gram-positive bacteria.

Record the name of every drug given, not just "antibiotic", on the vet log.

Anesthesia, travel & the vet visit

A guinea pig's gut and a dog's gut ask for opposite things around an operation.

Questions to ask any clinic

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ How many rabbit or guinea pig procedures do you handle in a typical month? | ☐ Can the cage mate stay alongside during a recovery or an overnight stay? |
| ☐ What is your fasting policy before anesthesia? | ☐ Who covers out of hours, and do they see guinea pigs? |
| ☐ What is your plan if my guinea pig is not eating within a couple of hours of waking? | ☐ Do you check every antibiotic against this species' risks? |

Two things that run opposite to a dog or cat

Fasting. Guinea pigs cannot vomit, so the reason for fasting a dog does not apply. A long fast leaves a gut that runs on constant food sitting idle for no benefit. What vets do ask for is a short fast, a couple of hours at most, for a narrower reason: to make sure the mouth is clear of food before a mask or tube goes in. If a clinic tells you to withhold food overnight, ask them to confirm it for this species.

Appetite is the finish line. A guinea pig recovering from anything eats less than it should, and eating is the whole game. If it is not eating within a couple of hours of waking, the plan is hand feeding, a change in pain control or a referral to a vet who sees guinea pigs more often. The warning signs in the days after any procedure are the same appetite and droppings changes as on the red flags page.

The carrier and the trip

- **A hard-sided, ventilated carrier** with room to lie down and turn around, not a wire cage. Wire bars flex under braking, and the open sides let a prey animal watch every passing car and person.
- **A hide spot built in:** a towel over the carrier, or a cardboard box or small tunnel inside, plus a toy or clean bedding from home and a layer of hay to nibble on the way.
- **Strap it in** with a seatbelt or wedge it in the footwell, with its side facing the direction of travel, so a hard brake pushes the animal against a wall.
- **Keep the car cool and ventilated,** the carrier out of direct sun and never in a closed trunk, and never leave the animal in a parked car, even briefly.
- **Keep the trip short** where you have a choice. A vet close to home can beat a highly rated clinic forty-five minutes away.
- **Take the cage mate** when the visit allows it.

Reading droppings, urine & hydration

Two minutes a day, and the fastest read you get on how the gut is doing.

Healthy droppings are small, firm, well-formed teardrop or oval pellets in dark brown, and plentiful. Count them roughly every morning, and look at them before you clean up.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
Fewer droppings, or none	The gut is slowing. Call at 8 to 12 hours with none.
Small or dry droppings	Not enough is going in, often the first sign of dental disease or too little water.
Watery, unformed or foul-smelling stool, or a soiled rear end	Diarrhea, not just a few soft droppings. A same-day vet call, especially with lethargy, a loss of appetite or a recent antibiotic.
Droppings that change after a new food	Trace it to the food. Add new foods one at a time, in small amounts, so you can.

Guinea pigs also eat some of their own droppings straight from the body, and that is normal.

Urine

Urine runs from pale to reddish-brown depending on the diet, so color alone does not mean blood. Straining, crying out while urinating, or a stained rear end do mean a bladder problem (page 29).

Hydration

- Fresh water must be available all day, in a bottle or a heavy bowl. A bottle tends to raise daily intake, which helps the bladder.
- Check the nozzle runs, because a clogged bottle looks full.
- Reduced water intake is a sign of stasis, and dehydration is part of what makes it worse.
- In hot weather, offer water-rich foods such as cucumber and keep water in more than one container.
- Nothing goes in the water: vitamin C breaks down quickly there and can make a guinea pig drink less.

WHAT TO TELL THE VET

When a guinea pig seems off, the questions are when it last ate, when you last saw a normal dropping and what the droppings look like now. A weekly weight and a daily look at the droppings make those answers easy to give.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 7.5 sq ft of solid floor for one guinea pig, 10.5 sq ft for a pair, roughly 2 to 4 sq ft more for each extra one (page 6)
- ☐ Sides at least 12 in (30 cm), good ventilation, no wire flooring
- ☐ Paper, fleece or kiln-dried pine bedding; no cedar, raw pine or sawdust (page 8)
- ☐ More than one hide, and more than one tunnel or chew in a shared cage
- ☐ A digital thermometer and humidity gauge in the room, and the enclosure out of sun and drafts (page 7)
- ☐ Out of reach of household cats and dogs, and never shared with a rabbit
- ☐ Unlimited grass hay, roughly 80% of the diet, never allowed to run out (page 10)
- ☐ Guinea pig pellets, about 1/8 cup per animal, from a bag less than 90 days past its manufacture date
- ☐ Fresh vegetables daily, bell pepper included (page 11)
- ☐ Water in a bottle with a working nozzle, or a heavy bowl, and nothing added to it (page 9)
- ☐ Two guinea pigs, sexed by you or by a vet (page 22)
- ☐ A gram scale, nail clippers with styptic powder, and a hard-sided carrier (page 14)
- ☐ A vet who sees guinea pigs found, and the number written down (page 24)

Targets at a glance

TARGET	VALUE
Room temperature	65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C), with humidity 30 to 60%. Heat stress can begin at 75°F (24°C)
Vitamin C	10 to 25 mg/kg a day for a healthy adult; 30 mg/kg or more if growing, pregnant, nursing or ill. A quarter of a medium bell pepper covers a typical adult
Hay, pellets, greens	Unlimited hay; about 1/8 cup (2 tablespoons) of pellets; roughly 1 cup of leafy greens, within 1 to 2 cups of produce
Weight	Boars 900 to 1,200 g, sows 700 to 900 g. Weigh weekly and track each animal's own figure
Nails	Trimmed every 6 to 8 weeks
Not eating	Call a vet at 8 to 12 hours without eating or droppings
Quarantine, a new guinea pig	2 to 3 weeks behind a closed door
Vet	An annual wellness exam, \$50 to \$100

Before your guinea pigs come home

- ☐ Enclosure set up, sited and bedded
- ☐ Hay in, in more than one place
- ☐ Room temperature checked with a thermometer, not by feel
- ☐ Quarantine space ready if you already keep guinea pigs (page 21)

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A VET WHO SEES GUINEA PIGS NOW IF

Not eating, or no droppings, for 8 to 12 hours · open-mouth breathing, wheezing or clicking · a hunched posture with teeth grinding · a bloated or firm abdomen · straining to urinate with nothing passing, or blood in the urine · panting, drooling and weakness in warm weather · diarrhea · a pregnant sow that has gone off her food, or one not delivered by day 70 · seizure-like scratching fits

TARGET	VALUE
Floor space	7.5 sq ft one guinea pig, 10.5 sq ft a pair, roughly 2 to 4 sq ft more for each extra
Room temperature	65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C), humidity 30 to 60%
Heat stress	Can begin as low as 75°F (24°C), most often above 82°F (28°C)
Diet	Unlimited grass hay, about 1/8 cup of pellets, roughly 1 cup of leafy greens
Vitamin C	10 to 25 mg/kg a day; 30 mg/kg or more if growing, pregnant, nursing or ill. A quarter of a medium bell pepper covers most of it
Weight	Boars 900 to 1,200 g, sows 700 to 900 g, tracked against each animal's own baseline
Fast before anesthesia	A couple of hours at most. Guinea pigs cannot vomit
Pellet bag	Use within 90 days of manufacture

Your numbers

Vet who sees guinea pigs _____

Guinea pig 1: name, sex, weight (g) _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Guinea pig 2: name, sex, weight (g) _____

Backup carer _____

Pellet bag manufacture date _____

SAY THIS AT THE CLINIC

"This is a guinea pig. Please check any antibiotic against the drugs that cause fatal diarrhea in this species. Please do not fast it overnight, and if it is not eating within a couple of hours of waking, what is the plan?" Take the cage mate with you if the visit allows it, and have ready when it last ate, when you last saw a normal dropping, and its weight (page 32).

Budget: setup & shopping list

United States retail ranges, last checked October 2026 and rounded to the nearest \$5. The low end is basic but correct gear, the high end is premium.

INITIAL SETUP, FOR A PAIR	TYPICAL COST
C&C cage or similar; check the floor area, 10.5 sq ft for a pair (7.5 for one)	\$100 to \$140
First bag of paper bedding	About \$15
Hay rack; check that it clips to the cage grid	\$5 to \$15
First supply of grass hay	\$15 to \$30
First bag of vitamin-C-fortified guinea pig pellets, 5 lb, small enough for a pair to finish within 90 days of manufacture	\$10 to \$20
First bottle of vitamin C supplement, a backup to fresh food	\$5 to \$15
Heavy food dish	\$5 to \$10
Water bottle	About \$15
Wooden hideout with a window	\$25 to \$30
A second hide and a seagrass tunnel, so neither of a pair is cornered	\$40 to \$60
Safe chew toys, more than one in a shared cage	\$10 to \$20
Nail clippers	\$5 to \$15
Styptic powder	\$5 to \$15
Hard-sided carrier; check the dimensions, with room for both cage mates	\$30 to \$35
Kitchen scale that reads in grams	\$5 to \$15
Digital thermometer and hygrometer for the room	\$10 to \$20
Setup, every row added up	\$300 to \$470
THE GUINEA PIGS THEMSELVES, ON TOP OF THE SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Guinea pig from a shelter	\$10 to \$60
Guinea pig from a pet store	About \$50
Specialty type (Teddy or Silkie)	\$100 and up

The hay, pellet, supplement and bedding rows are the first supply; after that they move to the monthly table on the next page. A habitat of about 8 sq ft at \$100 to \$109 covers one guinea pig; a pair needs a larger C&C habitat, closer to \$140.

Where not to cut corners: the enclosure size and the number of animals decide the long-term cost, so get the cage right the first time and budget for two from day one.

Budget: monthly costs & the vet

What a pair costs to keep once the setup is in place, on the same rounding.

MONTHLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Hay, pellet and vegetable top-ups for one guinea pig	\$30 to \$70
Hay, pellet and vegetable top-ups for a pair (the recommended minimum)	\$60 to \$135
Bedding top-ups for a pair	\$10 to \$35
Vitamin C supplement top-ups for a pair, while the diet falls short	\$5 to \$15
A pair, monthly: food, bedding and supplement	\$75 to \$185
Annual routine spending for a pair (hay, pellets, vegetables)	\$400 to \$1,620, about \$1,200 typical

VET	TYPICAL COST
Annual wellness exam	\$50 to \$100
Sick or emergency visit	\$100 to \$300 or more
Vaccines	None required
Neuter or spay	Not priced: fees are set clinic by clinic, so get a quote that includes anesthesia and pain relief

Prices move; treat these tables as a snapshot, not a quote.

Shopping list

- ☐ C&C cage or similar, sized for the pair
- ☐ Paper bedding, kiln-dried pine or fleece liners
- ☐ Hay rack and unlimited grass hay
- ☐ Guinea pig pellets with vitamin C, a 5 lb bag
- ☐ Fresh vegetables, bell pepper especially
- ☐ Vitamin C supplement, as a backup
- ☐ Heavy food dish and a water bottle
- ☐ A wooden hideout, plus a second hide and a tunnel
- ☐ Safe chew toys, more than one
- ☐ Nail clippers and styptic powder
- ☐ A hard-sided carrier
- ☐ A kitchen scale that reads in grams
- ☐ A digital thermometer and hygrometer

First 30 days

Before they arrive

- ☐ Enclosure built, sited out of sun and drafts, bedded and furnished with more than one hide (page 6)
- ☐ Hay in, and a vet who sees guinea pigs found (page 24)
- ☐ Ask the seller what hay, pellets and vegetables they eat, and buy some (page 10)
- ☐ Quarantine space ready if you already keep guinea pigs (page 21)

Day 1

- ☐ Weigh each guinea pig in grams and write it down (page 44)
- ☐ Check the sex of each yourself (page 22)
- ☐ Fill in the emergency card (page 36)

Week 1

- ☐ Make any change to hay, pellets or vegetables gradually, one item at a time
- ☐ Count droppings roughly every morning, and confirm the bottle runs (page 34)
- ☐ Weigh again at day 7

Weeks 2 to 3

- ☐ Book the first wellness exam with the vet (page 33)
- ☐ Short, low handling sessions, built up as they relax (page 15)
- ☐ Start daily vegetables, bell pepper included (page 11)
- ☐ Begin introducing foods one at a time, in small amounts (page 12)
- ☐ Quarantine, if any, runs 2 to 3 weeks before introductions (page 19)

Weeks 3 to 4

- ☐ Weekly weighing and the look-over become routine (page 14)
- ☐ First foraging toy or puzzle (page 46)
- ☐ Set a reminder for the nail trim, every 6 to 8 weeks (page 16)

What normal looks like by day 30

Eating hay all day, wheeking when the fridge opens, popcorning during floor time, and coming to the front of the enclosure rather than bolting for a hide when you walk in.

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Not eating, or eating much less	Dental disease, gut stasis, pain anywhere, scurvy, stress	Call at 8 to 12 hours (page 25)
No droppings, or very few	Gut stasis	Call at 8 to 12 hours (page 34)
Bloated or firm abdomen	A gut that has slowed or stopped, or another serious cause	Vet now
Hunched, teeth grinding	Pain, often gut or bladder	Vet now
Open-mouth breathing, clicking, wheezing	Respiratory infection, pneumonia	Vet now (page 28)
Panting, drooling, weakness in warm weather	Heat stress	Cool gradually, then vet now (page 7)
Straining to urinate, nothing passing	Blocked bladder or urethra	Vet now (page 29)
Squeaking while urinating, blood in the urine	Bladder stone or infection	Same day
Frantic scratching, thrashing, seizure-like fits	Mange mites, more often than a nerve problem	Same day (page 31)
Wet chin, dropping food, weight loss	Dental disease	Within days (page 26)
Rough coat, stiffness, swollen joints	Scurvy	Within days, same day if joints or gums are bad (page 27)
Sneezing, nasal or eye discharge	Respiratory infection, dust	Same day if repeated
Symmetrical hair loss down both flanks, skin normal	Ovarian cysts in a sow	Within days (page 30)
Hair loss with scabs, crusting, itching	Mites, lice, ringworm	Within days; wear gloves, ringworm spreads to people
A lump anywhere, especially the neck	Abscess, infected lymph node, cyst, tumor	Vet
Red, swollen or sore soles	Bumblefoot	Vet; check the floor and the nails
Diarrhea, a wet soiled rear end	Infection, diet, a reaction to an antibiotic	Same day (page 32)
Droppings softer after a new food	The new food	Hold it back, and watch
A pregnant sow gone off her food	Pregnancy toxemia	Vet now
Hiding all the time, bar-chewing, little interest	Boredom, a missing hide, or illness	Check the setup and call a vet (page 20)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Fresh water; check the bottle nozzle runs (page 9)
- ☐ Hay topped up and scattered, never run out (page 10)
- ☐ Measured pellets, about 1/8 cup per guinea pig, in the morning
- ☐ Fresh vegetables, bell pepper among them; pull what is uneaten after 30 minutes to a couple of hours (page 12)
- ☐ Spot-clean soiled bedding
- ☐ Look at the droppings while you do it (page 34)
- ☐ Handling and floor time, short and low (page 15)

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh each guinea pig in grams and log it (page 44)
- ☐ The look-over: eyes, nose, teeth, coat, feet, back end (page 14)
- ☐ Brush short coats every few days and long coats daily
- ☐ Rotate the greens, and add or move one enrichment item (page 46)

Often and regularly

- ☐ Change all of the bedding often
- ☐ Clean and disinfect water bottles
- ☐ Check the pellet bag's manufacture date: replace it at 90 days

Every 6 to 8 weeks

- ☐ Trim nails, with styptic powder open (page 16)
- ☐ Check the grease gland, and older boars for an impacted pouch

Seasonal

- ☐ Summer: check the room thermometer through the day, and have the cooling plan ready (page 42)
- ☐ Winter: keep the enclosure out of drafts and bedding dry, with extra hay

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam with a vet who sees guinea pigs, even when everything looks fine (page 24)
- ☐ Review the weight log for slow trends, not just single readings

Power outages, heat waves, travel & transport

A cool room is a far smaller problem than a hot one, and an animal that stops eating is in more trouble than one that is a few degrees cool.

When the power goes out

The danger line does not move: heat stress can begin at 75°F (24°C). What changes is that you are now the climate system.

Summer outage: the one to worry about

- Freeze bottles of water, wrap them in a towel and set them where a guinea pig can lie against one.
- Use cool wet towels, shade the enclosure with cloths and darken windows against direct sun.
- Keep unlimited fresh water in more than one container, and offer cucumber, melon or apple.
- Move the enclosure to the coolest room, often a tiled bathroom or a basement, and get air moving with a battery fan or open windows on the shaded side.
- Check the thermometer rather than guessing: a house without air conditioning climbs through the afternoon.
- Move out early if the room will not stay safe: a friend's house, or a vet with power. Decide at hour two, not hour eight.

Winter outage: drafts and damp

- Keep the enclosure in a draft-free spot away from windows and doors, and raise it off the floor, which is the coldest part of the room.
- Give plenty of bedding hay to burrow into, and change it often enough to stay dry.
- Add extra hay: it is insulation and the extra calories a cold animal burns.
- Check that water has not frozen, including the ball in a bottle nozzle.
- A bonded pair will huddle and do some of the work themselves.

KEEP FEEDING THEM

Unlike a reptile, a guinea pig must keep eating through an outage. Its gut has to keep moving, so hay and water stay in front of it the whole time.

Leaving town

A guinea pig cannot be left for days with a full bottle and a pile of food, because 8 to 12 hours without eating or droppings is already the time to call a vet. Arrange someone to look in daily to check appetite, droppings, water and the temperature, and fill in the pet-sitter sheet.

Transport and vet trips

- A hard-sided, ventilated carrier with a hide spot, a layer of hay, a toy or clean bedding from home, and the cage mate along when the visit allows it.
- Strap the carrier in with a seatbelt or wedge it in a footwell, its side facing the direction of travel.
- Keep the car cool and ventilated, the carrier out of direct sun and never in a closed trunk.
- Never leave a guinea pig in a parked car, even briefly: a closed car crosses into heat stress well before it feels uncomfortable to you.
- Keep the trip short where you can. Moving house: set the enclosure up and running at the new place before the guinea pigs arrive.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Names and normal weights (g) _____

My phone _____

Backup contact _____

Vet who sees guinea pigs _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Room temperature should stay under _____

Each visit

- ☐ Read the room thermometer. It should be 65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C). If it is climbing, follow the cooling steps (page 7).
- ☐ Top up the hay so it never runs out, and scatter it in more than one place.
- ☐ Measure the pellets: _____ per guinea pig, in the morning.
- ☐ Fresh vegetables: _____ (bell pepper every day). Remove what is uneaten after a couple of hours.
- ☐ Fresh water. Press the bottle ball or tilt it to check the nozzle runs.
- ☐ Spot-clean soiled bedding, and look at the droppings first: they should be small, firm and plentiful.
- ☐ Look at each guinea pig: bright eyes, clean nose, quiet breathing, eating hay, moving normally.
- ☐ Wear gloves and wash your hands if anyone is being treated for a skin problem.

Please don't

- Lift a guinea pig unless we agreed on it. If you do, sit on the floor, support both ends and keep it low: a fall can be fatal.
- Feed anything not on this sheet. Never vitamin C in the water, never fruit as a staple, never iceberg lettuce, and never anything from the never-feed list.
- Change the hay or the pellet brand: a new food can be refused for being unfamiliar.

CALL ME, AND THE VET, IF

Either guinea pig has not eaten or passed droppings for 8 to 12 hours · breathing with its mouth open, wheezing or clicking · hunched with teeth grinding · panting or drooling in the heat · straining to urinate · diarrhea · lethargic or not moving · anything else that looks wrong. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

Weigh on the same day each week, at the same time of day, and write the number even when nothing has changed: the unremarkable weeks are what make one remarkable week readable. A steady fall is a reason to call a vet. Bring this page to every vet appointment.

Equipment & vet log

Supplies and routine jobs

ITEM	DATE	NEXT DUE	NOTES
Pellet bag opened (manufacture date, replace by 90 days)			
Hay restocked			
Nails trimmed (every 6 to 8 weeks)			
Water bottles disinfected			
Thermometer and humidity gauge batteries			
Wellness exam (yearly)			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Month 1 is whichever month you start in.

TASK, BY MONTH	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Nail trim	☐		☐		☐		☐		☐		☐	
Pellet bag replaced	☐			☐			☐			☐		
Bottles disinfected	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Weight log reviewed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Wellness exam	☐											
Heat plan checked				☐	☐							

Vet visit log

DATE	WHICH PIG, WEIGHT (G)	REASON, FINDINGS, AND THE NAME OF EVERY DRUG GIVEN	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ More than one hide, so no guinea pig is shut out of cover
- ☐ More than one tunnel or other item worth having in a shared cage
- ☐ Hay scattered across the enclosure, not piled in one corner
- ☐ A foraging mat, a wooden puzzle or a tunnel for hidden vegetables
- ☐ Untreated wood chews, hay sticks or cardboard tunnels to gnaw
- ☐ A guinea-pig-proofed floor time space with no cords or gaps (page 20)

Monthly review

- ☐ Add one new item at a time, and none that are small enough to swallow
- ☐ Rotate the chew items
- ☐ Make one foraging challenge a little harder, and weigh daily while you do
- ☐ Supervised floor time at least once, with every cord and gap checked
- ☐ Try one new safe vegetable (page 12)

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

FLOOR TIME SAFETY, EVERY TIME

Cords and anything toxic out of reach, gaps they could squeeze into blocked, and a person watching the whole time. Never leave them unattended outside the enclosure.

Glossary, A to G

°F	Degrees Fahrenheit, the temperature scale on most United States thermometers. Page 7.
°C	Degrees Celsius; 0 is freezing, 100 is boiling water. Page 7.
Alfalfa	A hay made from a legume, not a grass, with more protein and calcium than a healthy adult needs. Suited to growing, pregnant and nursing guinea pigs. Page 10.
Anesthesia	Medicine that puts an animal into a controlled, unconscious state for surgery or a dental. Guinea pigs carry real risk under it and need a vet who does it regularly. Page 26.
Assisted feeding	Feeding a guinea pig that will not eat by syringe, with a critical care food, placed into the side of the mouth. Done as the vet directs. Page 25.
Boar	A male guinea pig. Page 22.
Boar butt	An impacted rectal pouch: a pocket behind the anus where droppings pack in, mostly in older intact males. Page 31.
Bordetella	A bacterium, <i>Bordetella bronchiseptica</i> , that causes respiratory infection in guinea pigs. Rabbits and dogs can carry it without looking ill. Page 28.
Bumblefoot	Pododermatitis: inflammation and infection of the soles of the feet, from wire floors, dirty bedding, obesity, overgrown nails or vitamin C deficiency. Page 31.
C&C	Cubes and corrugated plastic: an enclosure built from wire storage cubes on a corrugated plastic base, the usual way to get real floor area for the price. Page 6.
Calcium carbonate	The mineral that forms most guinea pig bladder stones. Page 29.
Cavy	Another name for a guinea pig. A "cavy-savvy" vet is one who regularly treats them. Page 4.
Cecum	The large pouch of the gut where bacteria ferment fiber. It is why hay and antibiotic choice both matter. Page 32.
Cervical lymphadenitis	An infected lymph node in the neck, which shows as a large swelling on one side. Page 31.
cm	Centimeter, one hundredth of a meter. 2.54 cm make an inch. Page 6.
Coat types	The English or American shorthair, Abyssinian (swirled hair), Peruvian (long-haired), Silkie, Teddy and Texel. Page 5.
Collagen	The structural protein that holds skin, joints, gums and blood vessels together. Vitamin C is needed to make it. Page 11.
Cystotomy	Surgery that opens the bladder to remove a stone. Page 29.
Enterotoxemia	Toxins from overgrown gut bacteria flooding the body, often after the wrong antibiotic. It can kill within one to two days. Page 32.
Foraging	Searching for food. A wild guinea pig can spend up to 80% of the day doing it. Page 20.
g	Gram, the unit a kitchen scale reads: 28 g make about an ounce, and 1,000 g make a kilogram. Page 14.
Gastrointestinal (GI)	Of the stomach and intestines, the gut. Page 25.
GI stasis	Gastrointestinal stasis: the gut slowing or stopping. The emergency this species is most likely to have. Page 25.
Gestation	Pregnancy. In guinea pigs 59 to 72 days. Page 22.
Gram-positive	A broad group of bacteria that includes most of the ones in a guinea pig's gut. Antibiotics aimed at them can wreck the gut. Page 32.
Grease gland	A gland at the base of the spine, above the anus, more prominent in males, that can get greasy and matted. Page 16.

REFERENCE

Glossary, H to Z

Hide	A shelter, such as a hut, pipe or tunnel, where a prey animal can retreat. Page 8.
in	Inch. 1 in is 2.54 cm. Page 6.
kg	Kilogram, 1,000 g, about 2.2 lb. Page 11.
Kiln-dried pine	Pine dried in a kiln, which drives off most of the oils. The one wood bedding generally accepted. Page 8.
lb	Pound, 454 g. Page 4.
Mange mite	<i>Trixacarus caviae</i> , a burrowing mite that causes itching so intense it can look like a seizure. Page 31.
mg	Milligram, a thousandth of a gram. Page 11.
mg/kg	Milligrams per kilogram of body weight: a dose that scales with the animal's size. Page 11.
Neophobia	Fear of anything new, including food. A reason to change a diet gradually. Page 10.
Neutering	Surgery on a boar so that he can live with sows without fathering litters. He stays able to father young for some weeks afterward. Page 22.
Nursing	Producing milk for young. Page 10.
Obligate nasal breather	An animal that cannot switch to breathing through the mouth when the nose blocks. An open-mouthed guinea pig is an emergency. Page 28.
Ovarian cyst	A fluid-filled sac on an ovary, very common in unsplayed sows. Functional ones make hormones. Page 30.
Ovariohysterectomy	Spaying: surgery that removes the ovaries and the uterus. Page 30.
Palpating	Feeling the abdomen with the hands for an enlarged organ. Page 30.
Popcorning	Repeated bouncing hops and twists. A sign of excitement. Page 17.
PVC	Polyvinyl chloride, a hard plastic. PVC pipe makes a tunnel or hide. Page 8.
Quarantine	Keeping a new animal apart, behind a closed door, so it cannot spread illness. 2 to 3 weeks. Page 21.
Quick	The blood vessel running through the center of a nail. Page 16.
Ringworm	A fungal skin infection, not a worm, that spreads from guinea pigs to people. Page 31.
Scurvy	Vitamin C deficiency, in which collagen production fails. Page 27.
Sow	A female guinea pig. Page 22.
sq ft	Square foot, an area of 12 in by 12 in. Floor space is counted in it. Page 6.
Styptic powder	A powder that stops a nicked nail bleeding. Page 16.
Toxemia	Pregnancy toxemia: a metabolic emergency in a late-pregnant sow. Page 30.
Ultrasound	Imaging with sound waves, the more reliable way to confirm an ovarian cyst. Page 30.
Urethra	The tube that carries urine out of the bladder. A stone can block it. Page 29.
Vet	Short for veterinarian. Page 24.
Wheek	The loud, rising food call. A learned response to expected food. Page 17.

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary references

- Merck Veterinary Manual: the guinea pig pages on providing a home, housing and nutrition, selecting a guinea pig, restraint and physical examination, anatomy, physiology and behavior, clinical techniques, infectious diseases, noninfectious diseases and common health problems. Floor space, the 65 to 79°F range, vitamin C per kilogram, dental, urinary, ovarian and foot disease, the usable antibiotics and the short fast before anesthesia.
- VCA Animal Hospitals (a United States veterinary hospital chain): guinea pig feeding, health problems, and bladder sludge and stones; health problems in rodents. The feeding list, the signs to act on and the antibiotics to avoid.
- North Carolina State University Veterinary Hospital: Caring for Your Pet Guinea Pig. University of Missouri College of Veterinary Medicine: antibiotic-induced enterotoxemia in guinea pigs. University of Illinois College of Veterinary Medicine: reasons to spay your guinea pig. Massachusetts Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals-Angell: urogenital disease in guinea pigs.
- LafeberVet (a veterinary education publisher): care of the pet guinea pig, care of the pregnant guinea pig, and behavior essentials for the guinea pig; the Lafeber pet-owner pages on grooming, guinea pig sounds, and whether a guinea pig is overweight. Coat types, the vitamin C content of common greens, weekly weighing and the pregnancy warnings.
- PetMD (a pet health site): gastrointestinal stasis and vitamin C deficiency in guinea pigs. Bonnie D. Wright, a veterinary anesthesiologist: anesthesia and pain relief in small mammals. The fasting rules.

Welfare organizations and husbandry references

- Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (RSPCA), United Kingdom: guinea pig company. RSPCA Australia knowledgebase: handling, heat, healthy guinea pigs, where to get guinea pigs, breeding and sexing, and enrichment. Heat stress from 75°F (24°C), sexing and the breeding timings.
- Humane World for Animals: guinea pig housing requirements. NC3Rs (a United Kingdom research body): housing and husbandry of the guinea pig. Oxbow Animal Health (a small-animal feed maker): the guinea pig care guide.
- GuineaLynx (a guinea pig rescue's information site): handling, introductions and quarantine.

Research

- Elsbacher and colleagues (2025), *Animals: guinea pig (Cavia porcellus) welfare, husbandry practices, human-animal interactions and behavior*. The link between food enrichment and play, and between hiding places and lower stress.

The law

- Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-6.5; California Code of Regulations, Title 14 § 671; Alaska Administrative Code, title 5, section 92.029; Georgia Rule 391-4-8-.05; Connecticut § 26-55-6; New Jersey Administrative Code 7:25-4.4; New York City Health Code § 161.01(c); District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j); Massachusetts regulations, title 321, section 9.02; the Hawaii Department of Agriculture and Biosecurity importing page for other animals, read on 3 October 2026; and each other state's rules, read on 1 October 2026. Library of Congress, Law Library: laws involving animals. The Local Switzerland: animals that cannot be kept alone.
- Prices were last checked in September 2026 at national pet retailers.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Floor space for one	7.5 sq ft (a veterinary manual's housing page); about 7 sq ft, 42 by 24 in (the same manual's owner page); 18 by 36 in for one or two (a veterinary publisher)	7.5 sq ft for one, 10.5 sq ft for a pair, with roughly 2 to 4 sq ft more for each additional animal
Room temperature	65 to 79°F (a veterinary manual); 65 to 75°F (the same manual's owner page); a comfortable 64 to 73°F (a welfare group); a ceiling of 80 to 85°F (a veterinary publisher)	65 to 79°F, with heat stress from 75°F and most often above 82°F
Daily pellets	1 to 2 teaspoons (a veterinary manual); 1 to 2 tablespoons (a veterinary hospital); 2 to 4 tablespoons (a veterinary publisher)	About 1/8 cup (2 tablespoons), measured, with hay and body condition deciding
Fresh produce	1 to 2 cups a day (a veterinary manual); half a cup of greens per 2 lb of body weight (a veterinary hospital)	Roughly 1 cup of leafy greens, within 1 to 2 cups of produce
Vitamin C	10 to 25 mg/kg for adults (a veterinary manual and a veterinary news site); 10 to 50 mg a day (a veterinary hospital chain); a 60 mg supplement (a veterinary publisher)	10 to 25 mg/kg, 30 mg/kg or more when growing, pregnant, nursing or ill
Bell pepper a day	A quarter of a medium pepper; 1 to 2 tablespoons of pepper (a veterinary hospital)	A quarter of a medium pepper for a typical adult
Nail trims	Every 6 to 8 weeks (a pet-owner publisher); weekly or as needed (a veterinary publisher)	Every 6 to 8 weeks
Fast before anesthesia	1 to 2 hours (a veterinary manual); a couple of hours at most (a veterinary anesthesiologist)	A short fast, a couple of hours at most
Adult weight and lifespan	Boars 900 to 1,200 g, sows 700 to 900 g (several sources); a mean lifespan of 6 to 8 years (a veterinary publisher)	The weight ranges; a lifespan of 4 to 8 years
When a sow can conceive	From 4 to 5 weeks (a veterinary publisher); from 4 to 8 weeks (a welfare group); from 2 months (a veterinary manual)	From 4 to 5 weeks, the earliest figure, since a mistake costs most there
When the pelvis fuses	6 to 9 months (a welfare group); a risk after 7 to 8 months (a veterinary publisher)	Roughly 6 to 9 months

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 3.0 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **3.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 51 pages. Safety: hay about 80% of the diet; pellets about 1/8 cup (2 tablespoons) per guinea pig daily; about 1 cup leafy greens within 1 to 2 cups produce; room 65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C), 30 to 60% humidity; heat stress from 75°F (24°C), most often above 82°F (28°C); bottle or heavy bowl, nothing added to the water; nails every 6 to 8 weeks; any steady weight fall is a vet call; no overnight fast before anesthesia; usable antibiotics: trimethoprim-sulfamethoxazole, chloramphenicol, fluoroquinolones; neutered boar off sows until the vet clears it; older boar's pouch cleaned as the vet shows; mite and ringworm treatment left to the vet; 2 to 4 sq ft more floor per extra guinea pig. Legal: 52 jurisdictions, Hawaii import permit. Costs: every item priced and rounded to the nearest \$5; setup \$300 to \$470; a pair \$75 to \$185 a month with food, bedding and the vitamin C supplement, food alone \$30 to \$70 for one and \$60 to \$135 for a pair; the budget now over two pages. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.1, Sep 2026.** Safety: heat danger line 80°F (27°C), heat stress from 75°F (24°C); antibiotics by drug class; fast before anesthesia 1 to 2 hours; nails every 6 to 8 weeks; short coats brushed every few days. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.0, Sep 2026.** Rebuilt, 39 pages. Safety: vitamin C by body weight, 10 to 25 mg/kg for a healthy adult and 30 mg/kg or more when growing, pregnant, nursing or ill. Replaced by 3.0.
- **1.0, Aug 2026.** First edition, 22 pages. Replaced by 2.0.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a veterinarian who sees guinea pigs, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, never for use at home. The law page is a summary as of October 2026, not legal advice.

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